



sacrifice that I am here today," Kartik says.

Chahar agrees. "Kartik would train five to six hours a day, but the self-belief and fearlessness came from his father. He sacrificed everything to make his son a cricketer. It proves that if you want something wholeheartedly, things eventually fall into place," he says.

While playing local tournaments in Agra and Bharatpur, Kartik met Vikas Yadav, co-owner of Aravali Cricket Club, by chance. "In one tournament in Jaipur, a team was short of a player and called me in. I scored 60 off 20 balls. Vikas *bhaiya* watched that game and offered me a place at his academy for free," Kartik says.

At 14, Kartik moved to Jaipur, emerged as the top batter in the privately run Aravali Premier League, and stayed on at Vikas' academy. "I lived at the hostel, and Vikas *bhaiya* ensured I had everything I needed. Even Lokendra sir felt it would be better if I stayed here and appeared for Rajasthan's age-group trials," Kartik says.

Over the last five years, Kartik has steadily chased his dream. From being another promising youngster, he has become one of the most talked-about cricketers from Rajasthan.

Early grind: Competition arrived early, and with it the need to keep turning up, regardless of conditions.

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At the Aravali club, he trained alongside Akash Singh, Ashok Sharma and Mukul Sharma, all of whom earned big IPL contracts this year.

"We don't even talk about the IPL," Kartik says, smiling. "We spend time together and just enjoy our cricket."

When in Jaipur, Kartik stays in rented accommodation close to the academy with five other players. He is a keen movie buff. "I love watching movies. Whenever I get time, I watch films with Ashok *bhaiya* and the others. I like action movies," he says. "A few weeks ago, we watched *Dhurandhar* and loved it."

He is not much of a foodie, preferring a disciplined diet that aligns with his training regime. Mornings, after all, arrive quickly here.

For now, though, none of that seems urgent. There is training to finish, a routine to return to, another morning to begin much the same way as the last. Kartik has learned, early on, that turning up matters more than where it might eventually lead.